



BEFORE

Northern victory had determined that the Union was indivisible and that slavery was abandoned forever. But crucial issues of reconciliation, retribution, and Black civil rights remained to be addressed.

LINCOLN AND RECONSTRUCTION

[The Emancipation Proclamation](#) of 1863 granted freedom to enslaved people, but only in those states in rebellion against the Union. Lincoln's "**Proclamation of Amnesty and Reconstruction**" of December 1863 pardoned Rebels who swore loyalty oaths and readmitted states when **ten percent of adult men** did so. However, the proclamation made no demands for Black rights beyond freedom, and would quickly restore former Confederates to political power.

With the [Thirteenth Amendment](#), the issue of slavery was finally resolved, but the conditions under which Rebel states could be readmitted to the Union was still to be decided. That task would fall to **Andrew Johnson** who had succeeded to the presidency after [Lincoln's assassination](#).

The so-called Radical Republicans were members of Lincoln's party who thought that his attitude toward the reconquered South had been far too lenient. Before Andrew Johnson became president, his fierce condemnation of rebellion encouraged Radical Republicans to think he would help them punish the South and remake it in the way they wanted. When Johnson announced his program for Reconstruction on May 29, 1865, it was not what they had hoped for.

The Reconstruction plan

Most of the presidential proclamation followed the policies advocated by Lincoln. An oath of loyalty to the Union and the promise to support the Constitution and obey Federal laws were required from all. Property rights—with the obvious exception of slaves—were restored and a framework was set up for working toward reestablishing state governments with new constitutions incorporating the Thirteenth Amendment.

Johnson was a complicated character. As a Southern Democrat he supported unquestioningly the rights of enslavers. He was a Unionist, however, who saw secession as treason and blamed disunion on the plantation owners. Johnson's modest origins alienated him from the aristocratic elite who dominated Southern politics. This helps explain a unique provision of his Reconstruction